

Broken Archive Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 35-45 min

Category	History	Time	35-45 min
Difficulty	Extended	ID	broken-archive

Big idea: The past survives as incomplete traces.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students reconstruct a past event from incomplete and biased sources.

Student Prompt

Inspect Broken Archive Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Broken Archive Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A partial archive with missing letters, dates, or voices. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Broken Archive Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Students reconstruct an event from incomplete evidence cards. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Broken Archive Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A source silence note asking who is absent and why. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — The past survives as incomplete traces.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Broken Archive Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Broken Archive Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can we know the past if we cannot observe it directly?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how the past survives as incomplete traces.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Can we know the past if we cannot observe it directly?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A partial archive with missing letters, dates, or voices.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- A partial archive with missing letters, dates, or voices.
- Students reconstruct an event from incomplete evidence cards.
- A source silence note asking who is absent and why.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/broken-archive/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/broken-archive/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/broken-archive/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Give each group a different combination of sources.
2. Groups reconstruct what happened.
3. Groups compare narratives and identify what evidence they lacked.
4. The class ranks which sources were most useful and most dangerous.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Can we know the past if we cannot observe it directly?
- How do historians deal with missing evidence?
- Is history discovered, constructed or both?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...